

By dawn on February 1, the US Marines and their ARVN allies had gathered enough troops around Hue to launch a counterattack on the communists. Their biggest challenge was the lack of intelligence regarding the size, power, and placement of Viet Cong and North Vietnamese units inside the city. American commanders had little choice but to order their units to advance. They could not have foreseen that it would take the better part of a month to clear Hue of communist troops or that along the way they would lose one man to every yard they gained inside the Citadel.



Gas attacks

The Marines, wearing gas masks to protect themselves, flush out snipers with tear gas during the battle to retake Hue. Both sides used tear gas.

Intense fighting

Come morning, Gravel and his men tried to break out of the MACV compound and retake other strategic points in the commercial quarter, but they were thwarted by communist forces that had dug in overnight. Marine reinforcements began to arrive on the southern outskirts of Hue, but their progress was slowed by intense street fighting against veteran NVA units.

The counterattack was also hamstrung by foul weather, which thwarted air support, and an initial reluctance to use close-quarter bombing and artillery in advance of an attack for fear of causing high civilian casualties and damage to historic buildings.